BharatTrip Refund Escalations: Business Case & Solution Proposal

Executive Summary (TL;DR) BharatTrip is experiencing a spike in customer/agent refund escalations despite stable refund volumes. Our analysis identified a severe operational disconnect between Support and Finance, leading to **100 dropped tickets** and **149 short payments**. By implementing a **Single Source of Truth (SSOT)** and an **AI-Driven Data Reconciliation Workflow**, we can eliminate manual data leakage, automate agent communications, and project an 80% drop in escalations over the next quarter without adding headcount.

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1. Defining the Problem

Customer and agent escalations regarding refunds are rising. The core underlying problem is a **severe operational disconnect between the Support and Finance teams**, characterized by siloed tracking systems and inconsistent definitions of refund statuses.

Key Communication Failures:

1. **Data Leakage**: Informal requests via WhatsApp and Email bypass the tracker altogether, meaning they are never reviewed or processed.
2. **"Closed" Status Ambiguity**: The Support team marks tickets as "Closed" once handed off to Finance, misleading the agent into believing the refund has been disbursed.
3. **Hidden Policy Deductions**: Finance applies necessary deductions (e.g., cancellation fees) and processes payouts, but this information is never relayed back to the agent by Support, causing "short payment" escalations.

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2. Data Analysis & Insights

By cross-referencing the `Support_Tracker`, `Finance_Tracker`, and `Escalations` logs via a deep database join, we identified the specific patterns driving the **155 total escalations**.

The Discrepancy Breakdown

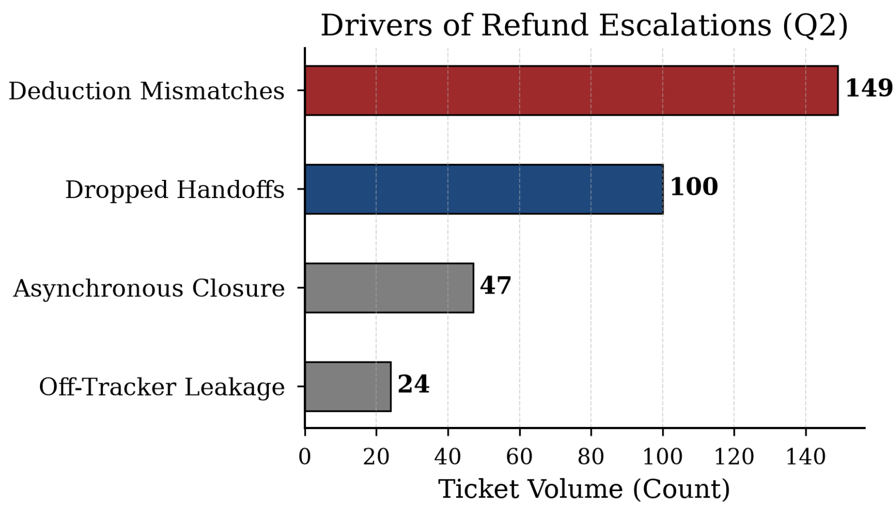

Figure 1: Metrics Data Leakage Visualization

Escalation Driver	Ticket Volume	Description
Dropped Handoffs	**100**	Logged by Support, but entirely missing from Finance tracking.
Deduction Mismatches	**149**	Amount promised by Support differs from amount disbursed by Finance.
Off-Tracker Leakage	**24**	Escalations with “no ref” originating from unlogged WhatsApp/Email.
Asynchronous Closure	**47**	Processed by Finance but missing from Support.

> **Insight:** While a naive net volume calculation (755 Support - 689 Finance) suggests only 66 missing tickets, our deep ID-to-ID database reconciliation reveals the true scale of the failure is **100 dropped tickets**, masked by duplicate records and asynchronous closures.

Future Validation

If given more time and access, I would validate the exact schema of the Support team’s ticketing software to understand why the “Closed” status is automatically triggered, and I would pull the API logs to see if Finance ever sends an automated webhook back to Support.

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3. Designing a Zero-Headcount Solution

To permanently bring escalations down, BharatTrip must establish a unified **Single Source of Truth (SSOT)** and automate the communication loop.

The Proposed Workflow:

1. **Unified SSOT Tracking**: Migrate both teams onto a single shared database.
2. **AI-Powered Ingestion**: Deploy an AI agent to monitor the Support Email and WhatsApp. The AI will parse unstructured messages and log them as structured tickets, eliminating "no ref" leakage.
3. **Automated Communication**: A system trigger automatically emails the travel agent when the status changes to `Paid`, detailing the exact payout amount and any deductions.
4. **Strategic Trade-offs**: We automate data entry and outbound communication, but deliberately keep *Finance payout execution* and *Support's initial vetting* manual to ensure strict financial compliance.

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4. The AI Prototype: Advanced Multi-Agent Architecture

To deliver a production-ready solution, I have developed `app.py`, a zero-friction **Streamlit Web Application** showcasing an advanced Multi-Agent architecture powered by `gemini-3.5-flash`.

Secure Integration (MCP)

In a production environment, the LLM will bridge with the internal SSOT database via the **Model Context Protocol (MCP)**. This guarantees that raw database credentials are never exposed to the LLM's context window, ensuring enterprise-grade security while allowing the AI to read/write records.

The Prototype Features

- **Metrics Dashboard**: Live KPIs tracking Escalations and Discrepancies to prove ROI.
- **HITL Workflow**: A UI for support staff to review AI-generated explanatory messages before they are sent to external agents.

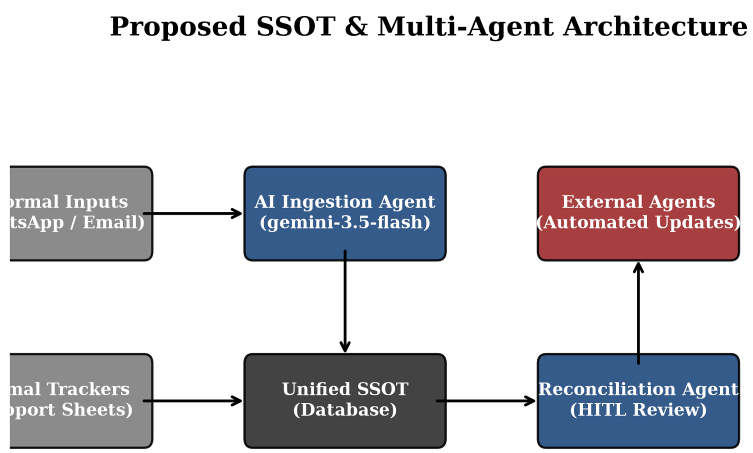

Figure 2: System Architecture Flowchart

5. Measuring Success

To ensure the solution is working, we will monitor two primary metrics over the next month: 1. **Escalation Rate**: The percentage of refund requests that result in a formal escalation. Target: >50% drop within 30 days. 2. **Tracker Discrepancy Count**: The number of tickets marked "Closed" by Support without a matching payout record in Finance. Target: Zero.

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6. Assumptions Made

As the brief was deliberately incomplete, I proceeded with the following assumptions to build the prototype: - **Finance is the ultimate authority on payout amounts**: If Support quotes 5000 INR but Finance pays 4500 INR, I assumed the 500 INR deduction is legitimate (cancellation fee) rather than a Finance error, meaning the fix requires better communication to the agent rather than a refund correction. - **WhatsApp/Email formats are unpredictable**: I assumed agents will not follow a strict template, necessitating an LLM to dynamically extract the `agent_name`, `route`, and intent from informal natural language.